

AIR FRYER BORICUA

La fritura sin el lío

The island's favorite fried foods — lighter, indoors, no oil smell that lingers for days. Standard air-fryer methods applied to the classics.

Authentic recipes · Bilingual · From the Ortiz kitchen
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How the Air Fryer Changes the Game

A note before you cook. Air fryers are small convection ovens. They crisp by fast-moving hot air, so results depend on three rules: don't overcrowd the basket (work in a single layer), lightly spray or brush oil on anything you want golden and crunchy, and shake the basket halfway through. Cooking times below are for a 5–6 quart basket — smaller baskets cook the same food in roughly the same time but in more batches.

Tostones — Double-Cooked Green Plantains

Air-Fryer Tostones

Tostones al air fryer · Crisp, golden, garlicky — the double-cook method translated to the basket.

Ingredients

- 2 green plantains, peeled
- 1 tbsp olive or vegetable oil (for spraying)
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 garlic cloves, mashed (optional), for seasoning

Steps

1. Peel the plantains and cut into 1-inch rounds. Toss with a little oil so they're lightly coated.
2. Preheat the air fryer to 390°F.
3. Arrange the rounds in a single layer in the basket. Cook 9–10 minutes until pale gold and slightly puffed.
4. Remove and flatten each round with a tostonera, the bottom of a glass, or a heavy mug — press gently to about 1/4-inch thick.
5. Spray the flattened rounds lightly with oil, return to the basket, and cook 8–10 minutes more, shaking halfway, until deeply golden and crisp.
6. Season immediately with salt and (if using) garlic mash so it clings. Serve with mojo or mayo-ketchup.

Pastelillos de Carne — Air-Fried Turnovers

Air-Fryer Pastelillos

Pastelillos al air fryer · Golden, flaky beef turnovers without the deep fryer.

Ingredients

- 1 lb ground beef
- 1/2 cup sofrito
- 1 packet sazón con achiote
- 1 tsp adobo
- 1/4 cup tomato sauce
- 12 empanada discs (Goya discos), thawed
- Oil spray
- 1 egg, beaten (for wash)

Steps

1. Cook the beef with sofrito, sazón, adobo, and tomato sauce until browned and saucy; cool slightly.
2. Place about 2 tbsp of filling on half of each disc, wet the rim with the egg wash, fold, and crimp with a fork.
3. Preheat the air fryer to 380°F. Brush each pastelillo with egg wash and spray lightly with oil.
4. Cook 12–15 minutes, flipping once halfway, until golden and crisp.
5. Let rest 3 minutes before serving — the filling is hot.

Bacalaitos — Cod Fritters in the Basket

Air-Fryer Bacalaitos

Bacalaitos al air fryer · Thin, lacy, garlicky cod fritters — crispy without a pot of oil.

Ingredients

- 1/2 lb salted cod (bacalao), soaked overnight and drained
- 1 cup all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- 1/2 tsp adobo
- 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1 cup water (approx.)
- 1 tbsp olive oil

Steps

1. Flake the soaked cod finely, removing any skin or bones.
2. Whisk flour, garlic powder, adobo, and baking powder; stir in water and olive oil to make a thin, pancake-like batter. Fold in the cod.
3. Preheat the air fryer to 375°F.
4. Spoon the batter into small rounds on a parchment liner in the basket — about 2 tbsp each, several at a time without touching.
5. Cook 10–12 minutes until set and golden, then flip and cook 2–3 minutes more to crisp the second side.
6. Serve hot with a squeeze of lemon.

Sorullitos de Maíz — Cornmeal Fingers

Air-Fryer Sorullitos

Sorullitos al air fryer · Sweet-savory cornmeal fingers, crisp outside and tender within.

Ingredients

- 1 cup cornmeal (masarepa fina or fine cornmeal)
- 1/2 cup water
- 1 tbsp butter
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 1/2 tsp salt
- Oil spray

Steps

1. Bring water, butter, sugar, and salt to a boil. Stir in the cornmeal until it forms a soft dough. Cool until handleable.
2. Shape into 3-inch logs, about 3/4-inch thick.
3. Preheat the air fryer to 375°F. Spray the sorullitos lightly with oil.
4. Cook 10–12 minutes, turning once, until golden and firm.
5. Serve with garlic mayo or a hot chocolate on the side.

Reheating Pernil So It Stays Crisp

Air-Fryer Reheated Pernil

Pernil recalentado · Leftover pernil, rescued: crackling skin, juicy meat.

Ingredients

- Leftover pernil, sliced or shredded
- Oil spray (optional)

Steps

1. Preheat the air fryer to 350°F.
2. Arrange pernil pieces skin-side up in a single layer; spray lightly with oil if the skin looks dry.
3. Heat 8–10 minutes until the skin crackles and the meat is warmed through.
4. Rest 2 minutes before serving. Never microwave pernil — it turns the skin to rubber.

House Rules for Crisp Results

Single layer, always. Spray or brush a thin coat of oil — it is what turns air into crisp. Shake or flip halfway through every cook. And season while food is hot, the way every fritura stand does, so salt

and garlic actually stick.